

FREE SAMPLE — CHAPTER ONE

CEOS TRAFFIC BRIDE

Marriage of Convenience — Book 1

THIRD
MAINLAND
BRIDGE
LAGOS
↓



CHAPTER ONE

The Proposal

The Third Mainland Bridge at 4:47 PM on a Friday was Femi Alagbada's personal hell.

Horns screamed. Danfos belched black smoke. Hawkers thumped Gala, bottled water and phone chargers against the tinted windows of his Range Rover. The Lagos sun turned his crisp white agbada into a second skin.

Google Maps blinked: 2 hours, 14 minutes to Victoria Island.

He had 43 minutes to save his inheritance.

His phone vibrated on the dashboard. *Tunde is already here. Lawyers are about to read the clause. Where are you? - Bayo*

If he wasn't at Eko Tower by 5:30 PM, the board would trigger the clause in his father's will. Thirty days to present a wife, or he would lose his 40% controlling stake in Alagbada Tech. Two hundred employees. His father's life's work. All of it would go to his cousin Tunde - a man who thought "cloud computing" meant selling power banks in Computer Village.

Femi hit the steering wheel. "God, abeg."

A sharp knock on his passenger window made him jump.

A girl stood in the narrow gap between his car and a tanker. She wore a faded black Bolt polo, a face cap pulled low, her face gleaming with sweat. She held up her phone.

"Oga! You dey go VI?" she shouted. "You don park for here for one hour. My rider cancel. I know another road. Leave your car for your driver. Enter my own. I go carry you reach VI in fifteen minutes."

Femi stared at her. Was this a new kidnapping format?

She rolled her eyes. "Oga, you wan lose that meeting abi you wan waka? I be Amara. I sabi this Lagos pass Google."

Behind him, her small silver Toyota Corolla idled, somehow still finding space where his Range Rover could not.

He had 42 minutes.

Femi grabbed his laptop bag, called his driver, "Kunle, stay with the car," and slid into her Corolla. The car smelled of coconut air freshener and ripe plantain. A small rosary swung from the rearview mirror.

"Seatbelt," she ordered, already pulling away.

She didn't drive in traffic. She negotiated with it. She spoke Yoruba to an agbero, Pidgin to a danfo driver, Igbo to a keke rider, all while threading the Corolla through gaps that shouldn't exist. She cut through Obalende, through a nameless street that smelled of fried fish and diesel, bounced over two potholes, and suddenly, the Atlantic breeze hit them.

Ahmadu Bello Way. Clear.

Femi checked his watch. 5:22 PM.

"You did it," he whispered.

Amara grinned, her gap tooth showing for the first time. "I tell you. Lagos na my office. That will be eight thousand naira. Surge."

He made the meeting with three minutes to spare.

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He found her three days later at the car wash beside 1004 Estate.

Amara Eze was sitting on a plastic stool, eating bread and groundnuts from a clear nylon, counting crumpled naira notes. Twenty-three. A final year dropout from UNILAG Computer Science - she had left in year three when her mother's illness got worse.

When the black Range Rover stopped, she nearly choked on her groundnut.

"You," she said.

"You never paid me," she added quickly, recovering.

Femi smiled. In jeans and a plain black t-shirt, he looked less like the terror of Victoria Island and more like the tech founders she argued with on Twitter. "I came to pay. And to propose."

The car wash boys stopped washing.

Amara stood up. "Oga, I tell you before. I no dey do that kind thing."

"Not that kind of proposal." He handed her a thick brown envelope. "Open it."

Inside was five hundred thousand naira.

Her hands began to shake. "Oga\... why?"

"Thank you for the ride. And a business proposal. A proper one, with lawyers."

He explained in thirty seconds. The will. The thirty-day clause. The cousin. The need for a wife.

"So go marry your girlfriend na," she said, frowning.

"I don't have one I can trust. The women I know want the company, not the man. I need someone real. Someone who didn't know who I was when she knocked on my window. Someone who saw a man in trouble and helped him."

Amara was quiet. The envelope felt heavy.

"My mama get fibroid," she said at last, her voice low. "LUTH say na 2.5 million for surgery. We dey do contribution for church. If this your proposal na film trick, Oga, abeg comot for here."

Femi sat down on the low fence, not caring about his jeans.

"It's not a trick. It's a contract. A marriage of convenience. For one year. On paper. You will live in the guest wing of my house in VI. You can keep driving if you want, or you can go back to school. I will pay for your mother's surgery today, and pay you ten million naira at the end of the year. After that, we divorce quietly. No one gets hurt. No touching unless you want it. Everything will be signed."

The air was still, except for the hum of a generator.

Amara stared at her Corolla with the cracked side mirror. At her phone with the cracked screen where her mother's missed call showed. At this man who was offering her a miracle dressed as madness.

"Na like Zee World be this," she whispered.

"With better lawyers," he said.

She wiped her palms on her polo and looked him straight in the eye. In that moment, she was not an Uber driver. She was a daughter desperate to save her mother.

"Money go enter hospital account first before I sign anything. And my own lawyer go check am. My pastor's son na lawyer."

"Done."

She held out her small, calloused hand.

"Deal, Oga CEO."

He took her hand. His was large, warm, soft. His thumb brushed the inside of her wrist by mistake, and a current shot up her arm so sharp she almost pulled away.

"My wife," he corrected softly.

Amara's heart hammered against her ribs. For a fake marriage, it already felt dangerously real.

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That night in Yaba, her one-room apartment was hot. Her mother, Mama Nkechi, lay on the mat, clutching her stomach but laughing through the pain.

"So you don't marry inside traffic? Only for Lagos! My daughter, shine your eye o. Rich man na engine oil, e dey stain."

"Na contract, Mama," Amara insisted, showing her the draft Femi's lawyer sent on WhatsApp. "Twelve months. Ten million."

But she kept hearing him say *my wife*.

In his penthouse in VI, overlooking the lights of Lagos, Femi swirled whiskey in a glass. His best friend Bayo was shouting on speaker.

"You are mad! You want to marry your Bolt driver? Your board will impeach you! Instagram will finish you! Tola will literally kill you and her!"

"She is different."

"Different how? She fine?"

"She told me my agbada looked like I borrowed it from my grandfather."

Bayo paused. "Omo. Marry her. Immediately. When is the family introduction?"

"Next week. At my mother's house in Ikoyi."

"Your mother will need an ambulance."

Femi laughed, then looked out at the city. Somewhere down there, a girl who could beat Lagos traffic was about to become Mrs. Femi Alagbada.

For one year only.

He had to keep telling himself that.

Want to know what happens next?

This sample covers only Chapter One. Femi and Amara's story continues for 15 more chapters — fake contracts, Ikoyi dinners, boardroom wars, a gala kiss that breaks all the rules, and a very Nigerian happily-ever-after.

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